



Composed brilliance: Mete Gazoz greets fans after his team's bronze-winning run at the Paris Olympics, the world champion balancing elite performance with a quiet ease that belies the spotlight.

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in anime, but there's only a very simple story behind it," he says.

Simple as it is, that origin story says something about Mete: even at 14, coming from a country with little Olympic archery pedigree, he already believed he would be a world champion someday.

"I think my best quality is my confidence. I don't know why, but I've always had it. When people ask me whether I was afraid of playing the Koreans or competing at the highest level, it's always strange to me because I never had any fear about these things," he says.

Supreme confidence

That confidence, perhaps, stems from more than his time on the

range. While archery came easily to him, Mete has lived with a painful stammer that makes communication difficult, as his body sometimes spasms involuntarily.

"It's a strange thing, my stammer," he says. "It's like when I think a lot and want to speak really fast, my brain can't keep up. It's sometimes really difficult for me to speak. I don't like public speaking for this reason. When I was young, my family took me to a lot of doctors and speech therapists. Finally, I gave up because I decided, 'I'm fine the way I am. I'm happy with this. I don't care what other kids say.' I've never been one to care what people think. Even as a child, I was independent. My thinking was always: I don't care what you think about me. My theory has

always been that if someone can't wait for me to complete my sentence, then I don't have time for them either," he says.

Mete says his stammer was less of a problem than his last name. "In Turkey, Gazoz (Uludağ Gazoz) is actually a very famous fizzy drink. It literally means gassy. As a kid, everyone made fun of my name more than anything!" he says.

The one place where Mete, born and raised in Istanbul's Sariyer neighbourhood, truly felt at home was the archery range. "I think the range was my real home. My father was an archer and later a coach, and my mother also used to shoot. All my earliest memories are about archery. I grew up going to competitions and knew all the archers long before I

« What I like most about archery is that there's no real chance for cheating »